

Becoming the Status Quo

This last transition is especially hard for innovators to accept: their transformation from radical outsiders to the embodiment of the status quo. I have found it disturbing in my career. As you can guess from the techniques I advocate as part of the Lean Startup, I have always been a bit of a troublemaker at the companies at which I have worked, pushing for rapid iteration, data-driven decision making, and early customer involvement. When these ideas were not part of the dominant culture, it was simple (if frustrating) to be an advocate. All I had to do was push as hard as humanly possible for my ideas. Since the dominant culture found them heretical, they would compromise with me a “reasonable” amount. Thanks to the psychological phenomenon of anchoring, this led to a perverse incentive: the more radical my suggestion was, the more likely it was that the reasonable compromise would be closer to my true goal.

Fast-forward several years to when I was running product development. When we’d hire new people, they had to be indoctrinated into the Lean Startup culture. Split testing, continuous deployment, and customer testing were all standard practice. I needed to continue to be a strong advocate for my ideas, making sure each new employee was ready to give them a try. But for the people who had been working there awhile, those ideas had become part of the status quo.

Like many entrepreneurs, I was caught between constant evangelizing for my ideas and constantly entertaining suggestions for ways they could be improved. My employees faced the same incentive I had exploited years before: the more radical the suggestion is, the more likely it is that the compromise will move in the direction they desire. I heard it all: suggestions that we go back to waterfall development, use more quality assurance (QA), use less QA, have more or less customer involvement, use more vision and less data, or interpret data in a more statistically rigorous way.